



AFTER

During the era of turmoil in Kansas, politics in the North was chaotic as new parties rose to replace the fading Whigs. In 1854, a new party would pose a challenge to the increasingly divided Democratic Party.

THE KNOW-NOTHINGS

From the mid-1840s, many Americans fixated on the threats Catholics and large numbers of immigrants presented to their image of a white, Anglo-Saxon, Protestant nation. **Secret societies** emerged and pledged **to oppose the influence of Catholics and new arrivals**. When questioned, they answered, "I know nothing." Opponents used the phrase to label the movement.

Know-Nothings shocked party leaders by **sending their members**, as many as 500,000, to the polls. By 1855, they dominated much of the East, replacing the Whigs as the opponents of the Democrats in the Mid-Atlantic states, California, and large areas of the South. **The party split in 1856** following a convention vote on slavery, and most Northern Know-Nothings would eventually support the Republican Party.